

Appendix C - Abrolhos Shallow Bank Marine Park

Data Analysis Report

North-west Marine Parks Network

Table of contents

|                                      |   |
|--------------------------------------|---|
| Data Analysis                        | 1 |
| Benthic ecosystem extent             | 2 |
| Demersal fish assemblage             | 6 |
| Significance of year and zone status | 9 |

Data Analysis

Statistical methods and model selection results underpinning the natural values reported in Appendix A.

## Benthic ecosystem extent

Table C.1: Habitat model selection results. Top generalised additive models (GAMs) for predicting the probability of occurrence of key habitats from full subset analyses. Differences between the lowest reported corrected Akaike Information Criterion ( $\Delta\text{AICc}$ ), AICc weight ( $\omega\text{AICc}$ ), variance explained ( $R^2$ ) and effective degrees of freedom (EDF) are reported for model comparison. Model selection was based on the most parsimonious model (fewest variables - shown in bold) within two units of the lowest AICc.

| Response              | Model                            | $\Delta\text{AICc}$ | $\omega\text{AICc}$ | $R^2$          | EDF          |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|----------------|--------------|
| Macroalgae            | <b>aspect+Z+year+status</b>      | <b>0</b>            | <b>1</b>            | <b>0.68906</b> | <b>9.91</b>  |
| Sand                  | <b>detrended+aspect+Z+year</b>   | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.999</b>        | <b>0.53046</b> | <b>12.05</b> |
| Kelp                  | <b>detrended+aspect+Z+status</b> | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.875</b>        | <b>0.59583</b> | <b>11.63</b> |
| Rock                  | <b>roughness+Z+year+status</b>   | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.763</b>        | <b>0.47062</b> | <b>10.93</b> |
| Sessile invertebrates | <b>detrended+aspect+Z+status</b> | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.713</b>        | <b>0.44166</b> | <b>10.62</b> |
|                       | <b>detrended+aspect+Z+status</b> | <b>1.815</b>        | <b>0.287</b>        | <b>0.44244</b> | <b>12.50</b> |
| Functional reef       | <b>detrended+aspect+Z+year</b>   | <b>0</b>            | <b>1</b>            | <b>0.49235</b> | <b>12.57</b> |

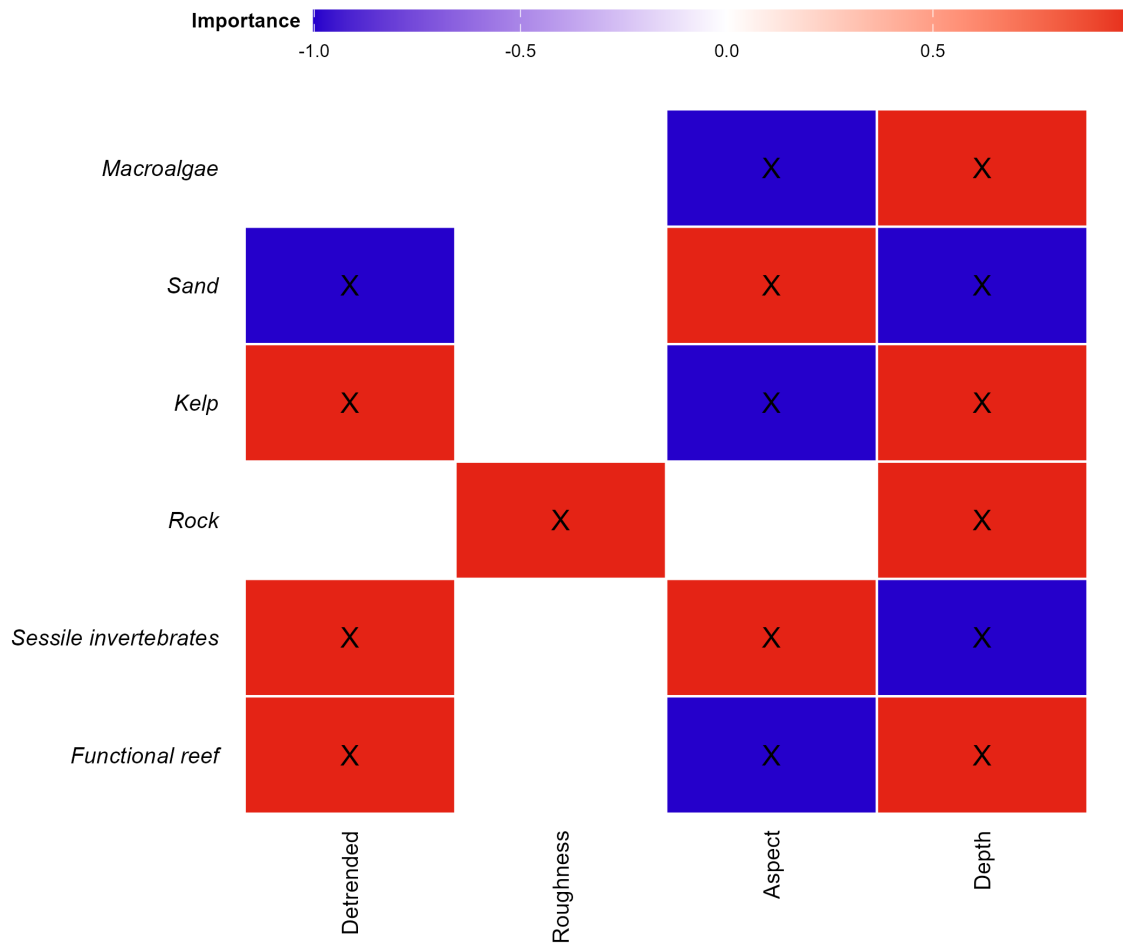


Figure C.1: Variable importance scores for predicting the probability of occurrence of main habitat categories. Response variables included in the most parsimonious top model are indicated (X), with the colour gradient representing positive (red), zero (white) and negative (blue) relationships. Aspect is a circular variable, so the direction of its relationship should be read from the response curves rather than the colour gradient.

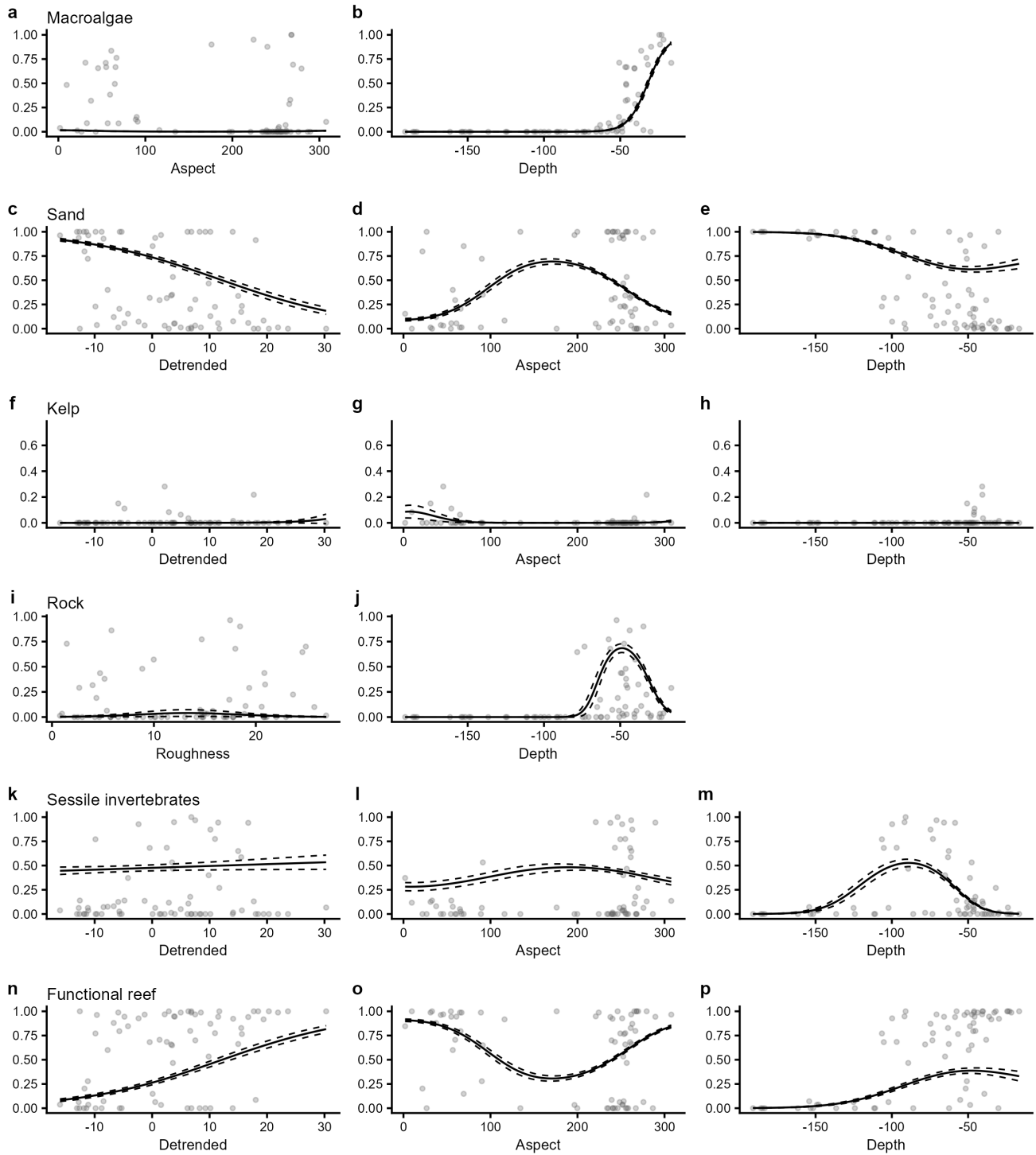


Figure C.2.1: Plots of the most parsimonious model found to predict the probability of occurrence of key habitat types in 2021. Individual panes display the predicted relationships between model covariates and the probability of occurrence of each habitat class. Solid lines represent predicted Generalized Additive Model (GAM) fits with other variables held constant at their mean value. Dashed lines represent upper and lower standard error bounds around the prediction, and points represent the observed data from that survey year.

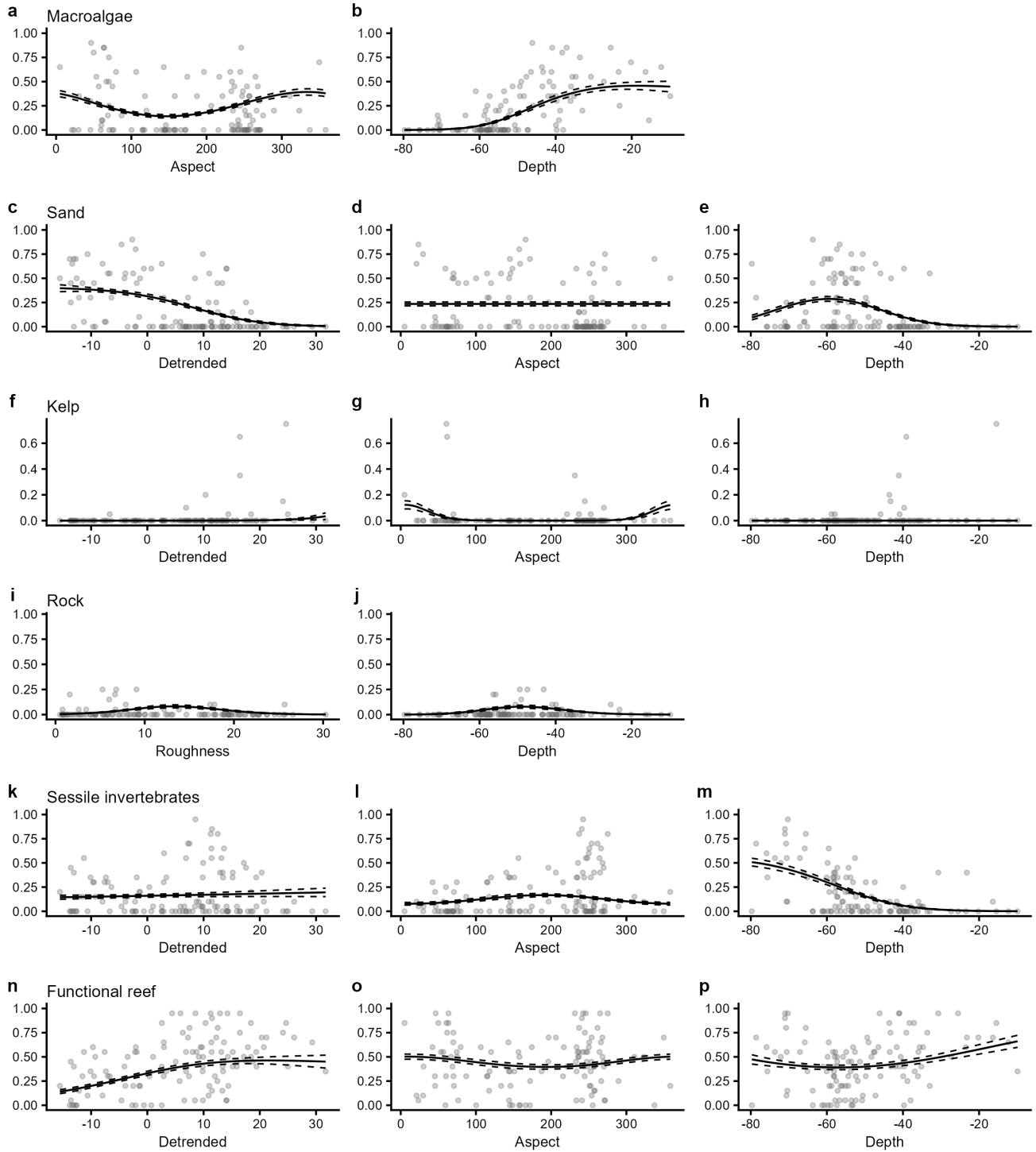


Figure C.2.2: Plots of the most parsimonious model found to predict the probability of occurrence of key habitat types in 2025. Individual panes display the predicted relationships between model covariates and the probability of occurrence of each habitat class. Solid lines represent predicted Generalized Additive Model (GAM) fits with other variables held constant at their mean value. Dashed lines represent upper and lower standard error bounds around the prediction, and points represent the observed data from that survey year.

## Demersal fish assemblage

Table C.2: Demersal fish model selection results. Top generalised additive models (GAMs) for predicting the species and abundance distribution of metrics of interest from full subset analyses. Differences between the lowest reported corrected Akaike Information Criterion ( $\Delta\text{AICc}$ ), AICc weight ( $\omega\text{AICc}$ ), variance explained ( $R^2$ ) and effective degrees of freedom (EDF) are reported for model comparison. Model selection was based on the best model (fewest variables - shown in bold) within two units of the lowest AICc. \*Large Reef Fish Index representing the biomass of all fish greater than 20 cm (B20) has been adapted here for stereo-BRUV data by removing sharks and rays.

| Response                | Model                        | $\Delta\text{AICc}$ | $\omega\text{AICc}$ | AICc           | $R^2$          | EDF         |
|-------------------------|------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|----------------|----------------|-------------|
| Species richness        | aspect+reef+year+status      | 0                   | 0.691               | 782.26         | 0.43309        | 5.78        |
|                         | <b>reef+year+status</b>      | <b>1.617</b>        | <b>0.308</b>        | <b>783.87</b>  | <b>0.40937</b> | <b>4.31</b> |
| Total abundance         | <b>Z+year+status</b>         | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.711</b>        | <b>1472.53</b> | <b>0.42306</b> | <b>4.00</b> |
|                         | roughness+Z+year+status      | 1.804               | 0.289               | 1474.33        | 0.42477        | 5.00        |
|                         | <b>detrended+year+status</b> | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.225</b>        | <b>2661.79</b> | <b>0.13643</b> | <b>4.82</b> |
| Large Reef Fish Index*  | detrended+aspect+year+status | 0.007               | 0.225               | 2661.80        | 0.13644        | 5.82        |
|                         | roughness+Z+year+status      | 0.291               | 0.195               | 2662.08        | 0.1475         | 5.90        |
|                         | Z+year+status                | 1.406               | 0.112               | 2663.20        | 0.12877        | 4.91        |
| Reef Fish Thermal Index | <b>Z+year+status</b>         | <b>0</b>            | <b>0.579</b>        | <b>176.69</b>  | <b>0.15287</b> | <b>4.80</b> |

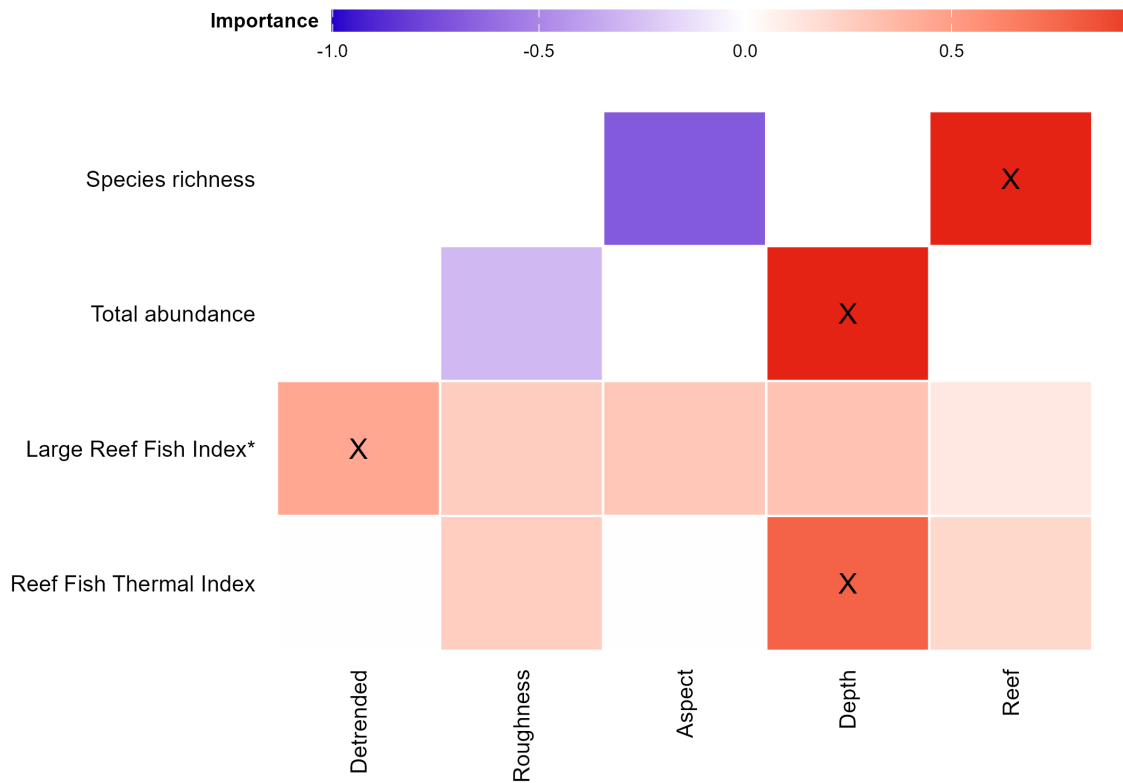


Figure C.3: Variable importance scores for predicting the probability of demersal fish metrics. Response variables included in the most parsimonious top model are indicated (X), with the colour gradient representing positive (red), zero (white) and negative (blue) relationships. Aspect is a circular variable, so the direction of its relationship should be read from the response curves rather than the colour gradient. \*Large Reef Fish Index representing the biomass of all fish greater than 20 cm (B20) has been adapted here for stereo-BRUV data by removing sharks and rays.

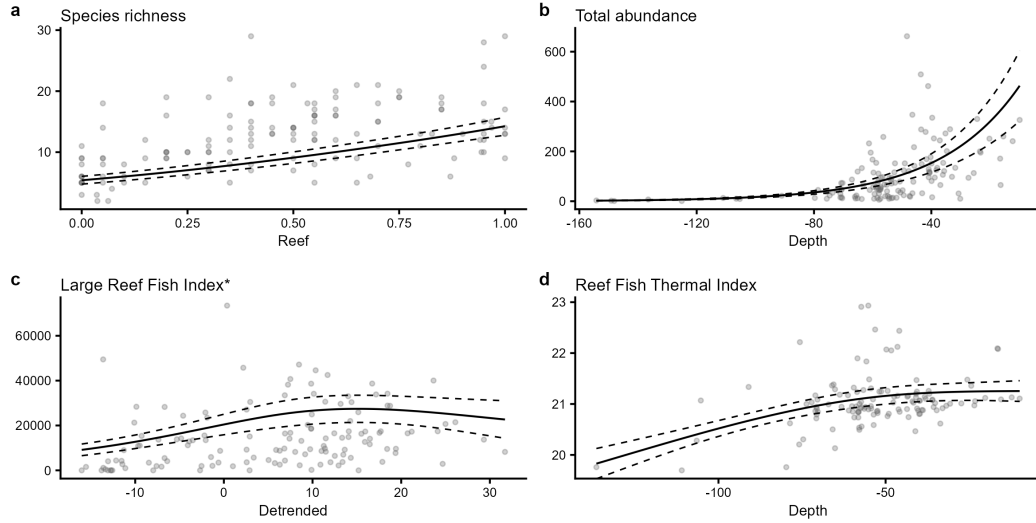


Figure C.4: Plots of the best model found to predict the probability of occurrence of key fish groups. Individual panes display the predicted relationships between model covariates and each demersal fish metric. Solid lines represent predicted Generalized Additive Model (GAM) fits with other variables held constant at their mean value, with year held at 2021 and zone status held at areas open to fishing. Dashed lines represent upper and lower standard error bounds around the prediction, and points represent the observed data from all survey years and zones. \*Large Reef Fish Index representing the biomass of all fish greater than 20 cm (B20) has been adapted here for stereo-BRUV data by removing sharks and rays.

## Significance of year and zone status

Table C.3: Significance of the year and zone status terms in each demersal fish GAMM. Estimate, standard error (SE), test statistic and p-value are taken from the parametric coefficient table of each model summary, one row per factor-level contrast (e.g. a survey year against the reference year, or No-Take against Fished).

| Response                | Term                           | Estimate | SE    | Statistic | p-value |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------|----------|-------|-----------|---------|
| Species richness        | Zone status: No-Take vs Fished | -0.135   | 0.068 | -1.989    | 0.049   |
|                         | Year: 2025 vs 2021             | 0.428    | 0.096 | 4.456     | <0.001  |
| Total abundance         | Zone status: No-Take vs Fished | -0.243   | 0.150 | -1.621    | 0.107   |
|                         | Year: 2025 vs 2021             | 0.010    | 0.215 | 0.048     | 0.961   |
| Large Reef Fish Index*  | Zone status: No-Take vs Fished | -0.012   | 0.166 | -0.071    | 0.943   |
|                         | Year: 2025 vs 2021             | -0.503   | 0.199 | -2.526    | 0.013   |
| Reef Fish Thermal Index | Zone status: No-Take vs Fished | 0.004    | 0.005 | 0.809     | 0.420   |
|                         | Year: 2025 vs 2021             | -0.004   | 0.007 | -0.521    | 0.603   |

Table C.4: Zone status test for each demersal fish metric, laid out by survey year. Zone status (No-Take vs Fished) is fitted as a single term across all years (no year by status interaction), so the status estimate, SE and p-value are the same in every row for a given metric; predicted values and their SE are shown per year, with other model covariates held at their mean.

| Response                | Year | Fished (predicted) | Fished (SE) | No-Take (predicted) | No-Take (SE) | Status estimate | Status SE | Status p-value |
|-------------------------|------|--------------------|-------------|---------------------|--------------|-----------------|-----------|----------------|
| Species richness        | 2021 | 8.816              | 0.914       | 7.704               | 0.723        | -0.135          | 0.068     | 0.049          |
|                         | 2025 | 13.531             | 0.567       | 11.824              | 0.724        | -0.135          | 0.068     | 0.049          |
| Total abundance         | 2021 | 87.831             | 19.303      | 68.916              | 12.477       | -0.243          | 0.150     | 0.107          |
|                         | 2025 | 88.749             | 7.896       | 69.637              | 8.911        | -0.243          | 0.150     | 0.107          |
| Large Reef Fish Index*  | 2021 | 24391.275          | 5572.767    | 24104.100           | 4205.027     | -0.012          | 0.166     | 0.943          |
|                         | 2025 | 14749.835          | 1796.243    | 14576.176           | 2134.496     | -0.012          | 0.166     | 0.943          |
| Reef Fish Thermal Index | 2021 | 21.143             | 0.162       | 21.222              | 0.133        | 0.004           | 0.005     | 0.420          |
|                         | 2025 | 21.066             | 0.059       | 21.145              | 0.083        | 0.004           | 0.005     | 0.420          |